

Photographs by RANJAN RAHII



LAPTOP KINGS: Legislators with their laptops outside Bihar Assembly

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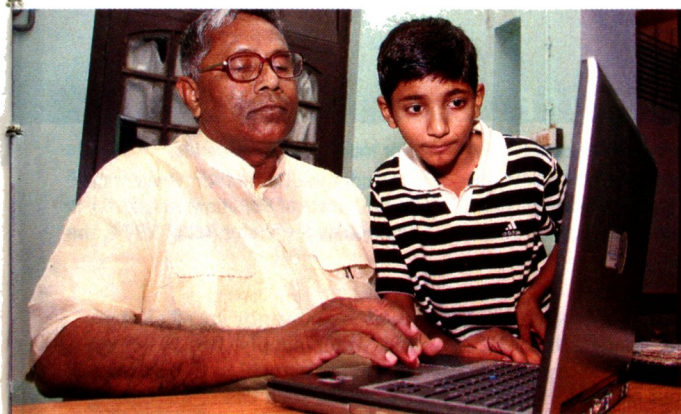
■ Governments in Karnataka have no hassles sanctioning laptops to their legislators—the last one allotted almost Rs 1.65 crore to 224 MLAs and 75 MLCs

■ Two years back, the Bihar Government sanctioned Rs 2.5 crore and handed out sleek laptops to 243 MLAs and 74 MLCs

■ In her second term, the Delhi Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit spent Rs 50 lakh on laptops and computers for MLAs

■ In 2001, the Maharashtra government sanctioned Intel Pentium III 650 MHz laptops, each costing around Rs 1.8 lakh, to its legislators

■ Former Andhra Pradesh chief minister Chandrababu Naidu offered computers to MLAs if they chipped in a third of the Rs 60,000 cost. Many took Rs 40,000 but never bought.



CLICKING TO GLORY: Bihar Speaker Choudhary takes lessons from his nephew

Bangalore-based geek that Lalu realised the utility of the computer. Two years back, the state Government sanctioned Rs 2.5 crore and handed out sleek laptops to 243 MLAs and 74 MLCs. An introductory three-day crash course was organised by the state undertaking Beltron during the budget session but less than 50 out of the 300 odd legislatures showed up.

Another five-day training pro-

gramme by the Bihar Institute of Public Administration and Rural Development (BIPARD) was devised, the first session of which concluded on May 5. The response was again not very encouraging with sporadic attendance and mass absenteeism for the entire duration of the course. Of the few who attended the classes such as Achutanand, Murlidhar Mandal and Ramesh Rishidev, most proved to be

slow learners with Mandal just about managing to learn how to log on and off. But he's quite content as "a beginning has been made". Assembly Speaker Uday Narayan Choudhary is said to have ordered sweets after he dispatched the first e-mail from his ultra-light Dell laptop. He later attributed his quick e-learning to his nephew Sidhant, who "examines his skills at the laptop every evening". Not all MLAs take lessons from their children on computers. They simply hand over the machines to them.

In Maharashtra, the legislators quote lack of software in Marathi as a deterrent. Many of them feel that loading Marathi software would be useful since several MLAs are not conversant in English. In 2001, the Maharashtra Government sanctioned Intel Pentium III 650 MHz laptops, each costing around Rs 1.8 lakh, to its legislators.

Bangalore maybe the country's IT capital but it wouldn't seem so if you talk to the Karnataka MLAs. As former chief minister H.D. Kumaraswamy once said, "Going out to the people in the field was much better than videoconferencing. The real human touch and feel is better than a click on the computer." This proved that he truly was a chip of the old block.

In Delhi, both the Delhi Government and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) are struggling hard to take the laptops and computers back from the legislators. In 1998-99 when the Congress came to power in the state, laptops were provided to 70 MLAs. But, according to information gleaned under the Right to Information (RTI) Act by Subodh Jain in 2007, as many as 17 of those who failed to get re-elected, have not returned the laptops issued to them after their assembly tenure got over in December 2003. The General Administration Department says, "There is no such provision to book the elected representatives for illegally retaining laptops which are actually government property."

In her second term, Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit spent Rs 50 lakh on laptops and computers for MLAs. Their term will end later this year when elections are due. The losers are likely to disappear and so will their laptops.

with Elora Sen, Aditi Pal, Manoj Verma, Amarnath K. Menon and Stephen David